In the last 10 days of March, the prime minister interacted with people from all walks of life through video-conferencing, taking their inputs, motivating them and, most importantly, involving various sections of society in the collective fight. An aide recollected how he insisted on interacting with people from diverse backgrounds because he wanted their direct suggestions and also wanted to instill a sense of confidence in them as India braced to face its biggest crisis since Independence.

On 20 March, the prime minister interacted with all the chief ministers of the country through a video conference wherein he called for tackling the challenge together. He directed them to maintain constant vigilance and monitor the spread of the virus. He insisted that the Centre and states must work closely together to combat the pandemic.

In an interaction with members of the industry, he requested them to encourage employees to work from home as well as to not cut down on workforce.

He also scheduled a video conference with leaders from the pharmaceutical industry and prodded them to expedite the manufacturing of Ribonucleic acid (RNA) testing kits which we would require in millions in order to quickly scale up testing. He assured them that the government is committed to maintaining supply of active pharmaceutical ingredients (APIs) and encouraged their manufacturing within the country. He also directed them to maintain supply of essential medicines and prevent black marketing and hoarding. By now, India had expanded its testing capacity to conduct over 50,000 to 70,000 tests per week in government laboratories. But the natural next step would be to expand the network of laboratories to include the private ones as well, in order to increase testing coverage. For reference, at this point, France was conducting 10,000 tests per week, the UK about 16,000, the US about 26,000, Germany approximately 42,000, Italy about 52,000 and South Korea approximately 80,000.

On a separate call with representatives from the media, he asked them to help spread awareness about how coronavirus spreads. He asked them to inform people about the locations of testing centres, who should get tested, whom to contact to get tested and follow home isolation protocols. He also urged the media to act as a link between the government and the people and provide continuous feedback, at both national and regional level.

Additionally, he spoke with radio jockeys (RJs) from across the country where he explained to them views of experts and steps taken by the